Brightside Coffee Co. - Employee Handbook

Welcome

Welcome to Brightside Coffee Co., a fictional chain of 12 neighbourhood coffee shops founded in 2014 in Riverton. This handbook explains how we work, what we expect from each other and what you can expect from us. It applies to all full-time and part-time team members from 1 January 2026.

Our values

We serve every guest as if they were a friend. We waste as little as possible: all our cups are compostable and unsold pastries are donated to the Riverton Food Bank every evening. We grow people: 70% of our store managers started as baristas.

Who to contact

Your first contact is always your store manager. For pay or contract questions, email people@brightside.example. For anything urgent outside opening hours, call the duty manager on 0800 555 0123.

Working hours and pay

Shifts

Stores open from 6:30 am to 7:00 pm, Monday to Saturday, and from 8:00 am to 5:00 pm on Sundays. Shift rotas are published every Thursday for the following two weeks. You can swap a shift with a colleague as long as your manager approves the swap at least 24 hours in advance.

Breaks

For a shift longer than 6 hours you get a 30-minute paid break. For a shift of 4 to 6 hours you get a 15-minute paid break. Breaks must be taken away from the counter.

Pay

Baristas start at $17.50 per hour. After passing the six-month review this rises to $18.75 per hour. Shift leaders earn $21.00 per hour. Pay day is every second Friday, by bank transfer. Sunday shifts are paid at 1.25 times the normal rate.

Tips

Card and cash tips are pooled per store and shared every pay day, in proportion to the hours each person worked.

Time off and leave

Annual leave

Full-time team members get 25 days of paid annual leave per year, plus public holidays. Part-time team members get the same amount pro rata. Request leave in the Rota app at least 4 weeks in advance. Leave between 15 December and 2 January is limited to 3 people per store and is given on a first come, first served basis.

Sick leave

If you are ill, call your store manager at least 2 hours before your shift starts; a text message is not enough. You get 10 days of paid sick leave per year. For absences longer than 3 days in a row, please provide a doctor's note.

Parental leave

After 6 months with us, parents get 16 weeks of fully paid parental leave, followed by up to 10 weeks at half pay. Please tell the People team at least 8 weeks before you plan to start your leave.

Volunteering day

Everyone gets 1 paid volunteering day per year to support a local charity of their choice.

Benefits and training

Free drinks and discount

On shift you get free drinks and one free pastry. Off shift you get a 40% discount in every Brightside store, and a 20% discount for one friend or family member with you.

Training

All new baristas complete a 3-day Barista Foundations course in their first two weeks. After 6 months you can apply for the Coffee Masters programme, a 10-week course that ends with a tasting exam. Shift leaders complete a 2-day leadership workshop.

Health and wellbeing

After 3 months, full-time team members can join the company health plan, which covers dental and eye checks. Everyone can use the free and confidential Employee Assistance Line, 24 hours a day, on 0800 555 0199.

Pension

Brightside matches your pension contributions up to 5% of your salary, starting after your first 3 months.

Conduct, safety and leaving

Dress code

Wear the Brightside apron, closed-toe non-slip shoes and dark trousers or a dark skirt. Long hair must be tied back. Your name badge must be visible at all times.

Food safety

Wash your hands at the start of every shift and after every break. Milk must be kept below 5 degrees Celsius, and fridge temperatures are checked and written down three times a day: at opening, 1:00 pm and closing.

Accidents

Report every accident or near miss to the shift leader straight away, and record it in the Accident Book the same day. Every store has a first aid kit behind the counter and at least one trained first aider on every shift.

Leaving Brightside

During the 3-month probation period, the notice period is 1 week for both sides. After probation it is 4 weeks for baristas and 6 weeks for shift leaders and managers. Unused annual leave is paid out with your final salary.